PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Cherokee XJ

1984–2001 · XJ

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **The unibody rails come first**
  Avoid trucks with rust on the unibody frame rails, especially near suspension mounts. If rust reaches the suspension bolts, you may have to cut and repair the rails before a lift. Check the steering-box and track-bar mounts for cracks as well.
- [ ] **Rockers, floors and lower quarters**
  Rocker panels under the doors and the lower rear quarters are the usual rust spots. Floors are relatively easy to replace; patch panels are cheap. Rust is much less common on Southwest trucks.
- [ ] **2000–01? Check the head**
  All 2000–01 XJs have the 0331 head. With the oil cap off, shine a light between the cylinder 3 and 4 exhaust rockers: a 'TUPY' mark means a revised head. Unexplained coolant loss, brown coolant or milky oil means a likely crack.
- [ ] **Idle it until the fan comes on**
  XJs are known for running hot. Idle for 5–10 minutes, make sure the electric fan kicks in, and watch the gauge on a hill. Bent pulleys suggest an overtightened belt and tired bearings.
- [ ] **Find the leak before you blame the rear main**
  Common leaks are the rear main seal, oil pan gasket, valve cover gasket and oil-filter-adapter O-rings. Oil runs down to the bellhousing, so check the top of the engine first.
- [ ] **Test drive for wobble and wander**
  Death wobble is usually the track bar. Wandering at speed means worn suspension or steering parts. A transfer case that pops out of 4WD may be worn.
- [ ] **Know the electronics era**
  1987–90 Renix trucks store no fault codes and are diagnosed with a multimeter, so buy one only if you're comfortable chasing sensors. The 1991 HO trucks and later are easier. Avoid 1984–86 unless you plan an engine swap.
- [ ] **Read the axle tags**
  ABS trucks have the Dana 35 rear, which is fine stock but weak with big tires. The Chrysler 8.25 is the common, decent rear axle, and a tow-package Dana 44 is worth extra.

YEARS TO KNOW

1984	BEWARE	Launch: unibody 'Uniframe', Quadra-Link coil front and leaf rear on live axles; 2.5 L AMC four or 2.8 L GM V6; NP207 Command-Trac or NP228/229 Selec-Trac. 1,200 lb lighter and 31 in shorter than the SJ Cherokee. No 4.0 until 1987: Off Road Xtreme recommends staying away from 1984–86 trucks
1991	SWEET SPOT	4.0 L 'High Output' with Chrysler multi-point injection, 190 hp; Chrysler 8.25 in rear axle available on non-ABS trucks. The HO is the XJ Off Road Xtreme recommends: easier to diagnose than the Renix 4.0, and more power

2000	BEWARE	Coil-on-plug ignition on the 4.0 (193 hp); NV3550 replaces the AX15; front Dana 30 goes low pinion. New '0331' cylinder head: early castings can crack between cylinders 3 and 4 and put coolant in the oil (Wikipedia). A revised 'TUPY' casting arrived late in 2001, so check the head on any 2000–01

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Rear axle assembly**
  1984 · NHTSA 84V-024
- ☐ **Rear differential pinion shaft**
  1984 · NHTSA 84V-045
- ☐ **Steering linkage couplers**
  1986–1987 · NHTSA 86V-159
- ☐ **ABS hydraulic system**
  1989–1990 · NHTSA 91V-003
- ☐ **ABS hydraulic control unit wear**
  1989–1991 · NHTSA 96V-260
- ☐ **Salt-belt front rotor corrosion**
  1990–1991 · NHTSA 98V-005
- ☐ **Salt-belt front rotor corrosion**
  1992–1995 · NHTSA 99V-340
- ☐ **Steering-gear frame weld omitted**
  1993–1996 · NHTSA 97V-069
- ☐ **Driver airbag missing arming lever**
  1995 · NHTSA 95V-057
- ☐ **Salt-belt front rotor corrosion**
  1996–1999 · NHTSA 00V-136

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **VIN (1987–1990)**
  The 4th character is the engine (M = 4.0 L six, E/H = 2.5 L four, B = 2.1 L turbodiesel); characters 6–7 are the body: 73/74 = 2WD two-/four-door, 77/78 = 4WD two-/four-door, 75 = Wagoneer. The 10th character is the year (H = 1987, J = 1988).
- ☐ **Rear axle**
  Dana 35 was standard throughout. A Chrysler 8.25 in came on non-ABS trucks from 1991 (27-spline, 29-spline from late 1996), and a 30-spline Dana 44 only on 1987–91 tow-package trucks. Read the axle tag or ring-gear size before you pay for 'the good axle'.
- ☐ **Transfer case**
  NP231 Command-Trac is part-time only (2HI, 4HI, N, 4LO). NP242 Selec-Trac adds a full-time 4WD position, so a lever with both 'Part Time' and 'Full Time' marks means Selec-Trac.
- ☐ **Wagoneer badge**
  The 1984–90 XJ Wagoneer and Wagoneer Limited are woodgrained Cherokees, unrelated to the full-size SJ Grand Wagoneer.
- ☐ **Right-hand-drive XJs**
  Jeep built RHD Cherokees for the US Postal Service and for Japan and the UK, and many Japanese trucks have come back for rural mail routes. US Drive Right recalled imported 1994–98 RHD Cherokees for failing several federal safety standards, so check an imported truck's recall status.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/cherokee-xj/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks